however, it would provoke the most dangerous insurrection of Akbar's short reign: the rebellion of the Uzbeks, led by none other than Ali Quli Shaibani, lord of Jaunpur, scourge of the Afghans, and heartbroken lover of Shahim Beg, the camel driver's son.

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But first, another interlude. In the half-year or so before Akbar left Agra for Jaunpur, he had twin sons, Hasan and Husain, born to a nameless mother. '[M]eadows of roses of joy blossomed,'[28] wrote Abul Fazl, but their petals soon withered and their scent turned sour. The boys died a month after they were born.

Akbar grieved, but he recovered soon enough. The twins were born in October 1564, the month of Akbar's twenty-second birthday. He was a young man just hitting his stride; the death of infants was not unusual – Akbar's own elder brother, the unfortunate Al-Aman, had died similarly; and a man who could tame mad elephants could surely produce more sons.

Why waste time in mourning? Akbar decreed a pleasure dome. Barely 5 kilometres from Agra was a village called Kakrali, a 'land of flowers' with the perfect climate for hunting and other pleasures.[29] Let a city of ease be founded here – Akbar named it Nagarchain and ordered architects to build him pavilions and gardens. His nobility hastened to follow suit, and soon the refashioned village was filled with courtiers and their amusements, Akbar at their centre, immersed 'sometimes in chougan-playing, sometimes in racing Arabian dogs, and sometimes in flying birds of various kinds'.[30]

Along the eastern borders of Akbar's kingdom, meanwhile, Ali Quli Shaibani was contemplating a more dangerous game. About the time that Abdullah the Uzbek began showing signs of his disaffection, Ali Quli was more productively occupied, fighting off ambitious Afghans in and around his fiefdom. The fief was Jaunpur – Ali Quli had conquered it, now he ruled it, though in the teeth of the resistance of its former Afghan lords, now settled farther east in Bihar and Bengal. Foremost among these were Fath and Hasan Khan, brothers who ruled the sprawling, well-equipped fort of Rohtas; and Sulaiman Karrani, the sultan of Bengal. Rohtas and Bengal both offered wary lip service to Akbar's throne, just as Akbar's representative, Ali Quli, offered them a watchful peace – it was a fragile,